

Dancing on the Edge: A Dive into Female Stardom with Nora Fatehi

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The Indian film industry is one where billions of aspiring youngsters move to Bombay every day hoping to make it big, but only a very select few do. An industry that is impossible to crack unless one has a strong network of industry insiders, a well-established family name or all the things that make up the ideal Indian woman. A young Moroccan girl, with none of these, but just pure talent and raw passion decided to come to India to pursue a career in Bollywood and managed to become a household name. In this essay, I will be using Usha Iyer's 'Dancing Women' to discuss the life and career of Nora Fatehi and provide a general commentary on the state of female stardom in our country.

Nora Fatehi's name rings synonymous with our favourite item numbers, immediately conjuring swaying hips, seductive eyes and graceful limbs to our minds. After experiencing only moderate success through reality shows like *Bigg Boss 9* and mediocre films like *Roar: Tigers of the Sundarbans*, Nora finally got her breakthrough in 2018 - but it wasn't because of a terrific acting performance or the role of a lifetime. She made a small special appearance in the film *Satyameva Jayate*, but those few minutes were enough to propel her from an unknown face to a recurring one on the Times' 50 Most Desirable Women in India list. A scintillating song and an even more alluring music video, with the sinuous Nora at the centre of it, *Dilbar* became the first Indian song ever to reach 20 million views in 24 hours on YouTube (Singh, 2018) and since then, has amassed over a billion views as of today. The song marked a turning point in her career as she began to get many more roles playing herself as special appearances in several item numbers, most of which outshined their respective movies at the box office, eg. O Saki Saki vs Batla House.

Even after having received no proper training in dance prior to her entry into Bollywood, Nora has garnered an impressive fanbase and meritorious respect for herself and her moves. While she has played a few roles in South Indian cinema as well, such as in Telugu movies like *Temper*, her classification in Bollywood is that of the dancer-actress. A quick look at her catalogue shows majority of her roles being those in production numbers and not as an actual character in the film. Usha Iyer

explains in *Dancing Women*, “The production number is structured around a display of dancing bodies, highlighting the experiential rather than narrational pleasures of the text, emphasizing spectacle over narrative, performance over characterization.” This renders Nora, as a dancer-actress who is unceremoniously discarded after the item song, simply just a spectacle - playing to the male gaze in highlighting her ‘to-be-looked-at-ness’.

Additionally, it acts as a commentary on the state of female stardom in the industry, which centres around desirability and replacement. Dancers like Nora are often cast in production numbers that exist outside of the main narrative, which means that their roles do not significantly impact the storyline. If their scenes were removed, the overall plots would likely remain unaffected, underscoring the peripheral nature of their contributions to the film’s narrative structure and the precarious nature of female stardom, particularly dancer-actors. Nora was Bollywood’s favourite item girl for a few years until she entered her 30s and sustained an ankle injury in 2024, which pulled her out of many projects she was going to work on. Her temporary absence from the scene was quickly filled by newer, younger dancer-actresses. This rapid replacement explains the industry’s tendency to prioritize novelty and youth over established talent. The comments from the PR agencies that promote the newcomers are scalding, saying “Nora’s career is over” and “She could eat 100 Noras for breakfast” (BBC Asian Network, 2025), reflecting the competitive and often cutthroat environment of Bollywood. This dynamic is reminiscent of the historical context of Hindi cinema, where women’s bodies have long been commodified and subject to constant scrutiny and comparison. As Iyer notes, the corporeal histories of Hindi cinema are marked by the choreographed performances of women, whose bodies are both celebrated and exploited for their physical appeal. Nora’s experience illustrates how this tradition continues, with female stars facing constant pressure to maintain a youthful and desirable image, lest they be replaced by ‘fresher’ talent.

The dancing body, however, as described by Iyer, has a certain presence and a ‘star persona’ that she believes ‘transcends the narrative-bound fictional character played by the actor.’ Iyer explains how the production numbers, and item songs in particular, become a space where the star gets to break away from the rigid barriers of the narrative and showcase their other talents - a stage where one can be unrestrained and ‘exceed the libidinal economy’ (Iyer, 2020) of the film. There is no doubt that the production number has been the predominant domain of the female performer, and in an industry that places much more value and star power on male actors, this is an opportunity that Nora grabbed with both hands. The dance number, albeit being hypersexualised and objectifying, can sometimes almost become this platform of empowerment, becoming bigger than the box office, as we have seen with many of her hit songs.

When Nora was getting started in her career, she recalled how she took up a lot of roles for free because she felt like making a name for herself and showing her talent was more important than making money at that time in her life. Later in her life, she also remembered how many directors would ask her for personal favours - which entailed making appearances in songs - in exchange for future roles in their movies, and how they never followed through. There is no doubt that in the Indian film industry, acting is viewed as more respectable and prestigious than dancing, which puts the dancer-actors in an inferior position, where they have to work harder to make the transition to serious acting roles - if they wish to. Getting out of the cycle of being typecast in the role of the seductress is a challenge, especially when it comes to someone like Nora, who was an ‘outsider’. She has candidly shared her early struggles in India, where she arrived with limited financial resources and had to share a small apartment with eight other girls. Yet, her determination to succeed drove her to learn and master the Hindi language and proactively create opportunities for herself. “I stopped relying on people - I’ll do it if I want to”, she said, when asked about her upcoming projects.

She has proved herself to be multifaceted, participating in reality TV shows, engaging in international collaborations and releasing songs. In her many interview appearances, she has always been candid, open and honest, encouraging other women to be authentically themselves and own their sexuality.

Despite the struggles she has faced - and continues to - when it comes to the Indian audience taking her 'seriously' and as someone beyond a pretty face and a sexy body, I have respect for Nora Fatehi and her attitude towards her career. The industry continues to be extra critical towards dancer-actors, reducing them to mere spectacles, but Nora managed to wrestle her way to the top and is determined to stay there. Nora has leveraged her position as a stage for empowerment for herself and other women to follow. She is bold, outspoken and unabashed, and refuses to let the industry control her own life's narrative. She has turned what is often seen as a transient, replaceable role into a lasting career, proving that one can find agency even within an industry that prioritizes novelty over longevity. While her journey jumpstarts an important conversation about the industry's biases, it also reflects a powerful narrative of self-made success. In a space that is notoriously difficult to break into - let alone sustain - Nora has refused to be boxed in, continuously redefining her place in the industry on her own terms.

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